Chris **Hickman**

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Summary

Backend engineer with 3+ years shipping production systems at Walmart scale, including agentic AI features for Sparky: Walmart's AI shopping assistant serving 1M+ monthly customers. Specialized in Java/Spring Boot microservices, distributed systems, and Kafka. Proven track record of owning features end-to-end from design through production, with measurable revenue impact. Open to backend or full-stack roles.

Technical Skills

Languages: Java (8-21), Kotlin, Python, JavaScript
Backend: Spring Boot, Kafka, REST APIs, Microservices
Frontend: React, HTML, CSS
DevOps: CI/CD, Kubernetes, Jenkins, Maven, Gradle
Cloud & Data: Azure CosmosDB, GCP (BigQuery, AlloyDB), PostgreSQL
Monitoring: Grafana, Splunk
Tools: IntelliJ IDEA, Postman, Git

Work Experience

April 2025 – Present

Software Engineer III – Sparky AI @ Walmart Emerging Tech, Hoboken NJ

Backend engineer on Walmart's agentic AI shopping assistant, owning features end-to-end across design, implementation, and production release in a high-velocity Java 21/Spring Boot environment.

- Led end-to-end engineering for the **Essentials Experience**, driving a substantial increase in Add-To-Cart rate through Sparky's agentic product discovery flow, and improving customer access to high-frequency everyday items.
- Owned and delivered **Sparky Ads integration**, inheriting established contracts and driving implementation to completion- enabling monetized AI-driven product recommendations and generating incremental revenue through partner brand placements.
- Drove **engineering excellence initiatives** focused on a scalable microservice architecture, maintainability, observability, and production readiness in an ecommerce environment used by over 1M+ monthly customers.

February 2023 – April 2025

Software Engineer II – Catalog @ Walmart Global Tech, Hoboken NJ

Enhanced and maintained Walmart's product setup pipeline, ensuring accurate product matching and catalog integrity. Built and optimized scalable, high-performance systems critical to product setup, including Matching and Normalization, through rigorous system design and test-driven development.

- **Modernized mission-critical Product Merge and Split APIs** via zero-downtime migration from Java 8 to Java 21, leveraging Spring Boot 3.x and Virtual Threads to reduce p99 latency by 40% for high-volume catalog transactions
- **Designed and optimized RESTful APIs** in a **microservice environment**, with JUnit and Mockito test coverage, improving data retrieval efficiency and system reliability.
- **Built and maintained Kafka-based event-driven microservices** within a **distributed systems** architecture, ensuring streamlined product data processing for 1M+ product changes a day.
- **Designed Spark jobs in PySpark**, processing millions of messages from Kafka and integrating with GCP storage solutions.
- **Led improvements in product matching systems**, enhancing data normalization and catalog accuracy for billions of products.

Education

BS Computer Science, Clarkson University - Potsdam, NY | Dec 2022 GPA: 3.86

- Strong foundation in algorithms, software design, and OOP (Java, C++). Graduated with great distinction.

AAS Graphic Art and Design, NCCC – Malone NY | May 2020 GPA: 3.944

- Mastered design principles, UI/UX concepts, and the Adobe Suite. President of the Art Club for two semesters.